Long Shot

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35418118.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Adora in a Suit (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Fluff and Smut, Basketball, particularly basketball written by a person who doesn't actually like basketball, so you know it's good, Gay Bar, play party (briefly), basketball star adora, reporter catra, A Tale as Old as Time, One Shot, Mutual Pining, upon reflection by 'it's good' i mean the basketball part is short and full of inaccuracies, SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra)

Language:
English

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by petty_labelle

Summary

With a roll of the eyes, Adora checked the ball back to her. “Still using the old rules?”

“Of course,” Catra scoffed. “Has society fallen apart?”

“So what does winner get this time?”

With her free hand, the one that wasn’t dribbling, Catra tapped her nail against her bottom lip. “Well, a pack of Now or Laters doesn't hold quite the same appeal it used to so... what do you want?”

“If I win, you'll come to the Elberon game?” Adora asked. She was trying not to light up in excitement but it was difficult. She could feel herself practically vibrating with joy. “I can fly you out and get you a hotel and everything.”

“Just get me the ticket, dummy. I can take care of the rest. I don't need you adding one more thing to your plate.”

Adora wanted to argue but this was already so much. She pursed her lips and nodded instead. “What do *you* get if you win?”

“The joy of conquering you,” Catra said simply.

A visit to an old haunt. A run-in with a familiar face. A quick round of the game that brought them together.

Notes

for enig17ma, who requested a love and basketball fic (blame l word: generation q). except i watched that movie maybe a

hundred times growing up and just never got into it (i didn't understand why she was straight). so instead i humbly offer you some love alongside some basketball and hope it suffices.

many thanks to wildangeline for the prompt (the first couple paragraphs) and to her, mxsinshine, and candycornsnake for running the spop creative flex.

See the end of the work for more notes

The bar was just as she remembered: elegant, but not stuffy, with beautiful leather banquettes and curtained mirrors. The nude portrait above the bar had been there as long as she could remember – all that had changed was the labels on the myriad bottles of expensive liquor lining the shelves below it. She looked around – there wasn't much of a crowd at this time of night – and a pair of eyes caught her attention from behind the bar.

"Hey, stranger." Pausing from her work to run a pincer through her (now shorter and much whiter) hair, Scorpia threw Adora a smile.

Freighton had three queer bars and, back when they were younger, Catra had convinced Adora to sneak into all of them with her. Sisters was the dive. Switch Hitters was the sports bar and, honestly, where Adora would probably prefer to be right now. But this bar, Velvet, was the "classy" one.

They never could afford the fancy cocktails at Velvet back then, but on a couple of occasions, a sweet butch with soft eyes and an even softer voice had given them a free drink to split before walking them to the door and telling them to stay out of trouble.

She'd traded in her red leather jacket for a red velvet vest and black dress shirt, but the bartender looked as kind as ever.

"Hey there, Scorpia," Adora said with a bright smile, ignoring the comfortable benches lining the room to take a seat on the backless stools at the white and gray marble bar. "It's good to see you."

"You too," Scorpia replied. She gently placed the snifter she'd been drying on the rack behind her. "What brings you around here?"

Her tone was friendly but with just a hint of curiosity that made Adora feel like blushing. Made Adora feel like maybe Scorpia already knew.

"In town on business."

“That so?”

Her outfit supported that farce. Adora couldn’t come up with anything that felt like it would match the mood...whatever the mood was supposed to be tonight. She wasn’t totally sure on that part still. But she had a black suit that her agent/friend Glimmer *swore* was meant to be worn without a shirt underneath, giving everyone a view of her long, tan neck and generous cleavage. It was the only thing Glimmer had bought her that wasn't a floofy dress so it would have to do.

The gold buttons on the jacket and sleeves were nice at least. They reminded Adora of the accents on her uniform. Helped her feel a little more comfortable with walking right into assured disappointment tonight.

Adora knew Scorpia was a sports dyke who probably followed the Sharks like most folks around here did ever since their hometown hero got drafted. Knew Scorpia would be aware that their next game was in 2 days. Clear on the other side of the country.

The only thing Adora was worse at than ‘business’ was lying. Thankfully Scorpia didn’t push any further on why Adora would spend her first free Saturday in forever coming to Freighton to do paper work or attend a meeting with people who wanted her to invest in something.

Before she had to think up some fake company and take this lie to its inevitably embarrassing conclusion, Scorpia saved her by nodding and asking, “Well, I'm glad you could join us for a drink. So what can I getcha?”

“Scotch rocks. Your pick,” Adora replied, already a little overwhelmed by the many varieties on the shelves. A strong drink would soothe her nerves and make sure she didn't imbibe too quickly. Adora had a tendency to just gulp down whatever was in front of her when she was anxious. Accidentally getting sloshed was not a good idea tonight.

“My pleasure.” Scorpia moved decisively, choosing one quickly and setting about her work.

The bartender's absence gave Adora a moment to appreciate the slightly updated ambiance: the moody music with deep but not overpowering bass; the low lights held in fancy sconces along the dark paneled walls. They'd really leaned hard into the old school feel of having to keep queer spaces intimate and tucked away.

There was a stage in the far corner, which was new. A platform that was only a couple inches above the floor, shielded behind black velvet curtains. Thinking about what *kind* of show was likely to be held tonight made Adora’s pulse quicken.

Along with a couple of people seated at the bar with her, there were three couples making use of the leather benches scattered around the room. Two were clearly on dates, nestled together and enjoying quiet conversation. The third was different – a tall woman standing over her seated companion, blocking the woman from view.

“Here you go,” Scorpia quietly announced. The rocks glass she placed in front of Adora was monogrammed with a thin gold ‘v.’

“Thanks.” Adora watched the glass for a second but wasn’t ready to make a move to try it.

Scorpia hovered for a bit. She must have been nervous, based on the way she seemed to be wringing her pincers behind the bar. Her brow was furrowed, face looking pinched and torn.

That certainly didn't help Adora's nerves.

Finally, Scorpia opened her mouth to say something after a long beat. She was cut off by an unbridled giggle from the other side of the room.

A beautiful, lilting laugh that died down with two long undignified squeaks.

All of the air escaped her lungs so quickly that Scorpia actually managed to look even more worried.

“You gonna be okay there, Adora, buddy?”

Adora didn't bother to respond directly. Waving Scorpia off, she turned in her chair to watch, not even able to think about how obvious she was being.

The person was still standing but the woman she was trying to chat up was now leaning back so far back into her seat that Adora could see her long wavy dark brown hair dangling over the back of it.

She tried angling to get a better view. Hell, she was basically on the next stool, who cared?

When Adora finally caught a glimpse, she did maybe consider that she should have readied herself on much more sturdy ground.

The woman sat, arms folded while her phone dangled in one hand. She was dressed in a crisp white button-up, sleeves rolled up to her elbows. It was accented by a black leather harness with wide straps, circling her shoulders and pushing from under her cleavage. Her legs were covered by tight black jeans and crossed at the ankles where her bare feet rested on the low wooden table in front of her.

She reached for her cocktail, not deigning to look back up to directly address the tall, muscular woman attempting to speak with her. After she recovered from her laughter, she resolutely but kindly waved the woman away, who complied with a slump of the shoulders.

Now alone, she sipped the rest of her cocktail and went back to furiously scrolling on her phone.

Adora returned to her chair in a daze.

'Okay. So this could *happen,'* she thought. *'We knew this could happen. That's the whole point. Head in the game, Grayskull.'*

Adora nodded to herself. Her eyes unconsciously floated once again up to the nude picture above the bar. They quickly shot back down.

'Nope. Not helping. Don't need that *kind of encouragement.'*

Scorpia cleared her throat.

"Hey, kid," she said in such a gentle way that it made Adora feel like she was once again a silly 19 year-old, sneaking in and trying to tipsily ask the bartender's advice on girls. "Do you want me to...maybe get her attention?"

Adora shook her head quickly. "No." She couldn't feel like she was being summoned. No. No, it had to be more of an...entreaty?

Adora's eyes scrambled for something that could help. She noticed the drink that had only been sitting there for a short time, while she'd already forgotten about it and literally everything else in this room.

With a breath for courage, Adora chugged down the scotch in two big gulps. It burned like shit and her entire mouth tasted like an extinguished match. Scorpia looked on in horror as Adora immediately went flush from the warmth of the booze.

She had to swallow *very* loudly to make sure it all stayed down, but Adora attempted a grin to signal that she was okay.

"Looks like I need a refill," she said. Pointing at the woman across the room as discreetly as possible, as if that mattered suddenly, Adora added, "Whatever she's drinking, can you send her another? On me, of course."

Scorpia nodded, holding back a smirk.

It felt like Adora waited an eternity as the rest happened. Whatever the drink was, it took too many minutes and too many ingredients for Scorpia to make. Or it was just a whiskey and soda, and Adora was losing her mind. Both felt possible.

Adora made sure to look down so she wouldn't be caught staring. She held her gaze to the bar for a few seconds while she tried to think of literally anything. Her mind kept coming up blank. It – the traitor – wanted to just focus on the scotch quickly catching up to her and how it made her feel just a tad bit more limitless.

She'd never been on a team with a losing season, not since 5th grade. She'd won rookie of the year. 3 conference championships. She'd met Serena Williams once and maintained some cool. This scenario right here was totally doable.

After Adora had repeated that mantra a couple more times, it felt like an appropriate amount of time had passed.

It was probably safe to look up, try out some eye contact. *Not* bolt out of the chair.

She took another short breath – and another not-short sip of her refreshed drink – and chanced a look over at the banquette.

It was empty. The woman, her drink, her phone all gone.

Adora had to fight the urge not to slump like the unlucky person who'd also gotten rejected by the same woman tonight. Maybe she could stay and get tipsy with them. She could drunkenly tell *them* all the shit she needed to say before she exploded.

She moved to turn back around, mind spinning, when a hand just barely drifted across the back of her neck, claws gently ghosting against her skin.

Adora froze in her seat, body still facing away from the bar. Of course. Of course Adora should have expected that she would have felt the need to stalk over quietly. Like she needed to assess her prey.

'Gods, too much scotch.'

"Hey, there," a familiar voice whispered.

So many times, Glimmer had mocked her for paying for the extensive sports package in her cable service but it was the only way Adora could hear that voice. She'd nearly fallen off of her couch the first time she turned on a Freighton State game and heard the color commentator snarking about the importance of showboating.

This, of course, was the *queen* of showboating talking. And now she had slid onto the stool next to Adora, sitting sideways so the blonde had her full attention.

Their eyes met. Catra's widened.

"Holy shit," she said, her tone empty. Adora expected a lot of reactions but completely neutral wasn't one of them.

When they were kids, her mothers used to chase Catra around the house to get her to brush her hair. But sat in front of Adora now, she was as perfectly coiffed as she looked on TV. Mane falling past her shoulders in wavy layers, a hint of eyeliner to accentuate her striking eyes, just a smidge of vanilla and smoke in her scent, like a candle that's just been lit.

"Hey, Catra," Adora whispered back. "No long. Uh, I mean, long time no see."

Catra relaxed a little, her different-colored eyes twinkling a bit in mirth.

"You know, I knew from your interviews that you hadn't gotten any better at public speaking but I feel like you practiced that one and everything. How much have you had to drink?" She was finally starting to sound amused by this situation, at least.

Adora lifted the glass slightly to show it. "On my second."

Catra gave a low whistle. “Straight whiskey? You're really looking for trouble tonight, champ.”

Adora rolled her eyes at the nickname. Catra's short piece in the local paper where she stepped out of her assignment and went a bit long on Adora's trajectory leading up to the playoffs had gotten some national attention. The first reporter to offer an in-depth look into the enigmatic mind of one of the most successful athletes of the decade. But Catra – who Adora hadn't spoken to in person in 7 years – ended the piece with a personal note to Adora, some inside joke about her bringing a title back to Freighton and an old callback. Champ.

“You don't have to use that anymore. Especially since we lost.”

Catra's eyes narrowed and her whole body tightened so quickly that Adora worried she'd upset her already.

Instead of a tirade similar to the last time they saw each other, when Adora was getting on the bus to head off to rookie training camp, Catra hissed, “Those calls were bullshit.” And suddenly Adora was 17 again, in on the rant and not the object of it. Being on this side was much preferred.

“Meff’s been reffing since the fucking dawn of *time* and suddenly they don't know a fucking foul when they see one? I tell ya – the fix is in. Do you know the stats on their calls for the last 4 years?”

Adora laughed, “Nope. Can't say that I do.”

She'd heard this from so many fans since then. Everyone rushed to blame the refs instead of Adora, who was the idiot that let an article – a glowing and very well-written one too, to be clear – get in her head and mess everything up.

Catra paused. She seemed to catch herself, finally setting her drink down on the bar and settling in to stay.

“Sorry. Hey, Adora.”

Adora felt her cheeks warm, even though she rationally knew that all that had been said was her own name.

“Hey. Good to see you.”

“You too,” she said and Adora didn't know if it was harder to contain her own surprise or her excitement at hearing those words. “So...looking for trouble?”

“Are you trouble?” is all Adora could think to ask. It felt both vague and a little too revealing.

“I'm willing to be,” Catra said. It was casual, like the implication wasn't doing all sorts of things to Adora.

With Catra, she never knew where a convo could take them. In the old days, they could spend hours literally just making jokes at each other or debating a point to death or asking actual raw questions. That last one was mostly Catra, who loved to encourage Adora ramble about where they were going after graduation or why Etheria existed.

Adora never was good at the questions piece.

“How are your moms?” she blurted out, remaining consistent.

Catra merely arched an eyebrow. “Adora. You talk to Razz, like, every week, right?”

“Yeah,” she replied unsurely.

“And I know she gives you an update on literally everyone in town, whether you’re interested or not. So maybe let's skip past the boring lives of Freightonians and jump straight to what you're doing here when you're supposed to be getting a good night's sleep before your flight to Thaymor tomorrow evening.”

“I missed home,” Adora said simply.

She missed *Catra* , more specifically, a feeling which she thought wasn't returned.

Not until she read the article.

All summer and then into the fall, Adora had been trying to get back to Freighton, trying to decide how to re-open a door between her and Catra that she had long figured was sealed shut. But public appearances and training and other obligations got in the way. And now it was almost 5 months later. Maybe that was too late.

Or maybe it wasn't? Razz wouldn't have been able to slip Catra's weekend plans into their check-in call if *Catra* hadn't wanted her to, right? Like, come on. Who tells their elderly neighbor that they're going to a play party? Razz didn't seem to realize it was a play party, at least, but Adora certainly had heard about the bar's new... entertainment.

"Missed home?" Catra repeated. She paused to lick her lips slowly. "I didn't see a car at Razz's. You get off the plane and come straight here or something?" She added a laugh at the end but her eyes made it clear that this was in no way a joke. She was assessing Adora, waiting for the trick.

Adora cleared her throat. "Heh. Yeah, more or less."

"No bags?"

"I just sorta dropped everything and jumped on a plane."

"Hmm." Catra's tail stuttered slowly behind her.

Adora couldn't remember if that was curiosity or danger. 5 months and it didn't occur to her to reacquaint herself with these details. 90% of the game is won in preparation.

Catra always hated that saying. But she prepped better than anyone Adora had ever played alongside.

“How's Christy?” Catra asked, proving Adora's point. No one else would look up who she'd last been rumored to date.

“Single, from what I’ve heard,” Adora answered.

Catra hummed quietly to herself again.

“What are you drinking?” Adora asked.

“Whiskey, water, dash of some sage bitters Scorpia makes. It’s pretty tasty.”

“Good enough to make you rush over when a woman sends you one?” Adora joked.

Catra certainly didn’t respond like it was a joke, the corners of her lips turning down.

“I saw you blow that other person off,” Adora continued. “But a stranger buys you a cocktail and you approach her immediately?”

“You’re not a stranger,” Catra answered quickly.

“You didn’t know it was me when you sat down.” It was work to hold in her smirk but Adora was still figuring out where Catra stood on everything yet.

Catra blinked a couple times before she replied, “Maybe I thought you were new in town and I wanted to be a kind face.”

“That’s true. Wildcat does like to greet newbies,” Scorpia called from the other side of the bar. “Now that you mention it though, she only chats up the *blonde* ones.”

“Thanks, Scorp. Want to show up at my job this weekend and point out every time I stutter?” Catra snarked.

“You never stutter,” Adora argued. “I’ve never seen you flub a single line.”

Catra snorted derisively. “Sure, the league MVP has time to catch all the Division I games.”

“I’ve never actually *won* M-”

“And you,” Catra turned to Scorpia. “Where’s this eagerness to help when I need a refill?”

“You could stand to pace yourself sometimes, Wildcat,” the bartender said kindly. “Speaking off-” Scorpia placed a couple of glasses of water in front of them.

“Anyway,” Adora tried to interrupt, “Like I was saying-”

Catra interrupted, “That water’s missing a couple of ingredients. Namely whiskey and bitters.”

“Remember our talk? There’s a limit to how happy our hour needs to be,” Scorpia told her.

“What’s the point of offering half-priced drinks til 8 if you don’t want anyone to take advantage of it?”

“There’s such a thing as taking *too* much advantage.”

“I DVR all the games!” Adora shouted in a frustrated whisper.

Catra and Scorpia paused in their back and forth, which definitely wasn’t making Adora jealous. Not at all. Catra slowly turned her head back to Adora, while Scorpia not-too-subtly pushed the water glass closer to her.

“Really? Well, I guess it’s just you and my moms in the Catra Driluth Fan Club then.”

“And every lesbian in the tri-state area,” Scorpia mumbled.

With one cut of her eyes, Catra sent Scorpia scrambling to find something to do to keep herself busy. There was still only a

handful of people in the bar. With the party not starting until 9pm, that probably wasn't going to change for a while.

"So how *is* work?" Adora asked. That seemed like a safe, vague subject. They could both pretend that she wasn't dancing towards 'and what were you trying to tell me by writing 10,000 words about my mechanics, upbringing, and all-consuming love of the game?'

For a moment, Catra looked like she was debating answering. But after a short while, she said, "The best. We played the early game today. I came straight from there. That's why I look like someone's naughty accountant."

She gestured towards her outfit, which would probably be understated for Catra – a person who Adora best remembered as wearing things that had gashes big enough to see an indulgent amount of fur underneath – except for one accessory.

"They let you wear the harness on camera?"

"We're liberal but we're not *that* liberal, Dor." Catra rolled her eyes. Then she added, almost as an afterthought, "I keep it in my trunk sometimes."

"In case of emergencies?"

"Yes," she answered shortly.

"What could that possibly entail?"

Adora quickly realized that setting Catra up like that was a terrible mistake. This, unfortunately, only came to her as Catra smiled wickedly, sharp fangs highlighted by the low lights.

"What if some poor damsel has a leather daddy emergency and needs me?" Catra's grin somehow managed to grow.

'Lucky person,' Adora thought.

“That's good,” she choked out. “Uh, work. Not you being a le-” Adora faked a cough so she wouldn't have to finish that sentence.

Her eyes drifted over to the covered stage. Catra's attention seemed to follow.

“Listen, if you're uncomfortable or anything-”

“I'm not!” Adora argued quickly. “I've got some experience. Is this how you spend your free time?”

“It's an indulgence I allow sometimes,” Catra replied, which didn't really feel like she was admitting much of anything to Adora. “Does that surprise you?”

Adora almost laughed. Regaining a bit of her footing, she said, “You bought me handcuffs for my 18th birthday. Not exactly subtle.”

“It was a helpful gift for my hopeless best friend. Are you trying to imply it was something more?”

At the time, Adora had certainly thought it was. She’d nearly turned as red as a tomato when she pulled the cheap pink fuzzy toy out of the paper bag Catra had shoved it into.

“What exactly was that supposed to help me with?” Adora asked.

“To get you to come out of your shell.”

“Oh, was *that* my problem?” She tried to keep her voice light and joking but she genuinely was interested in Catra’s view on why they never escalated past friendship, even when everyone was *certain* that they must have been dating.

“Yep,” Catra said quickly. She moved to take another drink and apparently that was that. “So you were planning to stay for the show?”

Adora had to blink at her a couple of times. The plan hadn't really been scouted out past just seeing Catra. Adora wasn't even sure what words she wanted to say to her.

It occurred to her that she hadn't accounted for variables either. What if Catra was meeting someone? What if Catra was *dating* someone? Razz would probably have mentioned that but her aunt wasn't as omnipotent as she thought.

So Adora decided to just cut the shit and lay it all out.

"I came to Velvet hoping to see you," she said, not quite admitting that she came to *Freighton* itself just for Catra. "I don't know what you were intending for tonight but I'd love to tag along."

Catra nodded her head slowly as she chewed on that. "Careful. Don't want to accidentally agree to anything that might jeopardize your nice little girl-next-door image."

"Well, a journalist recently wrote that I was basically a workaholic megalomaniac-"

"I didn't use literally any of those words."

"-So I think my whole 'effortlessly perfect' image is blown."

"Aww, people know that you have to *try* to be so amazing?" Catra sarcastically replied. "How horrifying. If you'd read it closely, you'd know that the whole point of my story was that people should stop expecting so much of you. It's fucking ridiculous that people keep trying to hold you to impossible standards-"

"Because I've proven I can do impossible things," Adora interrupted.

"Because you're too stubborn to admit when you struggle or how much you've sacrificed." Catra had managed to maintain the same sort of passionate tone that she usually had when talking about the sport but at the mention of 'sacrifices', her voice threatened to

steep into bitterness. “You're just one person. You can’t hold it all.”

It’s possible Catra didn’t remember. She’d given Adora a very similar talking-to after a particularly crushing defeat their freshman year of college. They were playing their rivals from Bright Moon U, an annual tradition that FSU hadn’t won in nearly a decade. The team was in a rebuilding stage after losing a handful of stars to the draft and graduation. Catra and (especially) Adora were supposed to bring fresh energy and talent that would turn the team around. That game, Adora was everywhere: hitting threes, grabbing boards, playing d like she never had before.

They lost by 20. When Adora was crying afterward in the shower, Catra came in – and *yes,* Adora can *hear* how gay that sounds now, thanks – and laid into her for trying to take the loss on by herself.

“If we had won, would you own that victory alone?” Catra had asked. Adora shook her head. “Well, then you don’t get to own this defeat alone.”

Adora reached for her glass, hoping the chill of the ice in her hand could help ground her in the present.

“I know,” Adora said quietly. It took her a few seconds to add, “Thanks for reminding me. You were always good at that.”

A clawed hand reached over and took hers off of her drink. Adora didn’t dare look up, convinced that she’d probably cry in the middle of this bar if she did.

“I’m sorry about the finals. And I’m sorry if the article put more pressure on you.”

Adora shook her head quickly because Catra could never. Not intentionally, at least. Pressure wasn’t Catra’s thing. She set expectations. Boundaries.

“Why didn’t you text?” Adora asked. Because texting seemed to be well within the strong boundaries Catra had set after she left. She didn’t often initiate but she’d respond at least.

Catra’s hand withdrew, leaving Adora’s feeling empty and cold.

It took Catra about a minute but she mumbled out, “I thought you’d have enough people hitting you up.”

“I reach out to you all the time. I obviously would have appreciated it.”

“You text me ‘happy birthday’ and ‘Merry Christmas’ and ‘can you believe they blew that lead?’ Doesn't really leave an opening for an engaged dialogue.”

“Please,” Adora scoffed. “You sent me an 8-page message when Elberon beat the Kingdom of Snows.”

“Because that game was bananas! Hell, the stadium almost rioted after that.”

“Don’t get her started on that game again,” Scorpia pleaded. For the first time, Adora noticed that she’d slowly made her way back towards their end of the bar. “You two alright?”

“Relatively speaking,” Catra answered for both of them.She didn’t even wait for Scorpia to walk away before telling Adora, “You’re right. I should have said something. I knew you’d be feeling low. Blaming yourself for everything.”

They sat in silence for a long beat after that, Adora feeling awkward and pretending that Scorpia wasn’t still definitely eavesdropping.

Tentatively, Catra cleared her throat. “Okay. You’re here for...what – a few hours? What do you actually want to do while you’re back?”

“Whatever you want to do,” she answered easily.

Catra all but rolled her eyes. “What do *you* want, Adora?”

It wasn’t a question that people often asked her. The blonde drummed her fingers against the bar but there was really one main thing she was interested in. “Tell me about you.”

“Razz tells you-”

“Then tell me all the stuff she doesn’t know. Do you still go to the same places? Do you still like the same things?”

“Is this that thing people do when they come back to their old stomping grounds? They do a tour of their townie friends’ lives? After I tell you about my thrilling Wednesday nights watching HGTV with a glass of wine, am I gonna have to drive you to the high school so you can lecture young people about how cool you used to be?”

“No, but I’m glad you’re finally admitting I was cool,” Adora said with a smirk.

“You were a dork then and you’re a dork now.”

“Hey, I dated a racecar driver. That’s very cool.”

“That’s a good point,” Catra admitted. “Any way I could get her number from you?”

With great exasperation, Adora huffed, “Catraaaaa.”

In response, she released her glass and crossed her arms before turning to face forward in her chair. “After my moms moved to warmer weather, I tried remodeling the house but got bored after a month so it’s basically the exact same as you’d remember it. I’m addicted to iced coffee, even if it’s freezing outside. I’ve been trying to choose a hobby for about 4 years now. I do yoga with Scorpia’s girlfriend 3 times a week and I’m as bad at it now as I was when I started a couple years ago.” Catra paused, considering if she’d forgotten something. “My favorites are still Razz’s berry

pie, peanut M&Ms, and complaining that people are cheating at 2K when I lose."

"We should play sometime," Adora said immediately since that was just about the only excuse she could find in there for them to spend more time together. She'd wait until she was back in Salineas to quietly hire a yoga instructor, master all the poses, and then casually suggest to Catra that they video call Adora for their sessions. Foolproof plan.

"Not if you still cheat."

"Being aware of your opponent's game plan isn't cheating. Also, didn't you always tell me that if you're not doing everything possible to win, you're not trying?"

"I think you've found my new catchphrase." She turned back to Adora. "Now that that's out of the way, what's next?"

Oh. Apparently Catra wasn't as curious about her life as she was about Catra's. Adora put her drink to her lips to hide her frown.

"Fine," Catra said with a sigh. "What's next after you tell me everything?"

"It's okay. You don't have to pretend to be interested."

"I just don't want you to feel like this is an interview," Catra returned with a shrug. "Obviously I want to know everything."

Adora perked up. "Really?"

"I'm not saying it again."

She had to fight to contain her grin. This was a time when booze really wasn't on her side. Adora began to ramble about traveling and the locker room and her personal trainer, Huntara, who she was sure hated her and the restaurants in Salineas that she hoped Catra would visit with her.

It was probably too many words. Way way too many words, if Scorpia's ever-deepening brow furrow was anything to judge by. But Catra listened intently the whole time, not even interrupting once.

Adora finished with a deep breath. She ignored how a pincer pushed the forgotten water glass closer to her.

"I'm happy for you," is all Catra said in return. It would have been an empty platitude from anyone else. From Catra, though, that simple sentence made something deep inside Adora's chest finally unclench.

"Thank you," she replied genuinely. "I'm happy for you too."

They held each other's gaze for what was probably way too long in a public space, just sharing a moment in easy silence. Where Catra's eyes had been guarded with the false show of openness before, Adora watched them start to slowly unshutter in earnest. She was only beginning to see Catra as the person she was now and not just a version of the girl she'd been dreaming of for years. And Adora wanted so much more.

"What's next?" she asked, repeating Catra's words back to her. The bar was slowly filling up around them. All of the new voices chipped into their bubble of intimacy and Adora was reluctant to stay and let that happen.

"Well, we could probably go catch a game." Nope, too distracting. "We could call up a couple folks and see if they're up to anything." Adora really liked their old crew but she didn't want to take any time away from Catra to hear what Kyle was up to these days. "We could stay and catch the show. It's probably gonna start in a few minutes, honestly."

Adora was about to ask why this play party had a show included – just for curiosity's sake! – when a tall, thin figure slinked over between the two of them.

"Darlings, you absolutely *have* to stay," they practically purred.

Adora jolted in her seat, swiveling to face them quickly. Their skin (which Adora was sure wasn't the correct word for it) was a lime green color and everything about them seemed...pointed. The corners of their eyes, their ears, the tips of their long fingers. Their tone.

Catra looked at them as if she'd been expecting them to appear at any moment.

"DT, Adora," Catra said by way of introduction, lazily pointing to each of them.

"Charmed," they said as they extended their hand for Adora to kiss. She did it, quickly, just so they could get their interaction over with. "Now, as I was saying, you *must* stay and join us. I've already reserved a booth for the two of you."

Velvet seemed to have two little booths in the furthest corner, up near the stage, probably a holdover from the old decor. Adora had to angle to see them, especially now that there were about 50 new bodies in the room, but they were indeed empty. And private, it seemed. People hovered nearby but not nearly as close as they were starting to get to the two of them still seated at the bar.

"VIP," DT continued. "Very exclusive for the...sports...ball...person." They just barely hid a confused frown.

Catra looked like she was opening her mouth to decline but Adora jumped ahead of her.

"That sounds perfect. Thank you so much."

Before Catra could argue, Adora was dumping $20s onto the bar for their tab and clambering out of her seat to follow DT.

The booth was the kind of old leather that squeaked as Adora slid onto the bench. She was grateful for the small wooden table that the u-shaped seat wrapped around since it gave her someplace to pretend to casually lean onto as she gestured for Catra to sit

closer. Their knees were practically touching as DT removed the tiny gold 'reserved' sign and sauntered away with a grin.

"They'll be expecting you to tip generously," Catra told her.

"Perfect. I love supporting queer artists or whatever," Adora replied. She still wasn't totally sure what was happening tonight but she was confident that she could come up with a good excuse for them to leave and be alone. Then, she just had to figure out a place to take Catra. There wasn't much they used to get up to. Usually just playing some ball in the park near their houses.

Her plotting was interrupted by a sinewy blonde server in a red dress with thin straps. On a little round tray, she carried two fresh cocktails and a couple more glasses of water. Scorpia was not being subtle about hydration.

"Here ya go," she said as she placed the drinks on the table in front of them. She winked and disappeared before Catra could open her mouth.

DT took to the stage, emerging from behind the still-closed curtains. For the first time, Adora noticed their attire for the night – a black latex catsuit. In their hand was a small wireless mic. They had stage presence, Adora could give them that. With just a clearing of their throat, the previously-bustling room quieted down immediately.

DT began by greeting the room and instead of thanking them for being there, they congratulated everyone on their excellent taste for joining *DT* that evening. They set the ground rules. Consent, communication, confidentiality. And no getting naked.

"Let's respect this classy establishment. Plus, darlings, I don't need anyone's bare ass on the bar. I drink there."

Someone mistook that as a joke and heaved a drunken laugh. DT shot their eyes in the person's direction, silencing them instantly.

"Don't forget to tip our lovely performers and bartenders. Big spenders are very very sexy." And then with a flourish, they disappeared behind the curtain.

Loud music began to pour out of the speakers overhead, boisterous jazz horns. It was vaguely familiar, like a song from a musical that Glimmer had probably made Adora watch one late night.

The curtains slowly opened on the stage to reveal a curvy-dark skinned figure dressed in a plush tan fur coat. With an air of total confidence and eyes sparkling with mischief, she began to lip sync along with the lyrics, something about 'being good to Mama.'

She was jovial, in on the joke, as she smiled at the crowd that started milling closer and closer to the stage. She baited them with a peek of her bare shoulder before giving a cheeky grin. As the song built to a crescendo, she whipped the coat off, revealing a gold flapper-style dress underneath.

Next to Adora, Catra cheered and whooped along with the crowd. "Give me some cash?" she asked the blonde without taking her eyes off the stage.

Adora reached into her wallet and handed over a handful of bills just as the performer twirled a spin that had the fringe on her dress floating. It was hypnotic, especially under the spotlights. As her spin finished, the performer slipped her fingers under the shoulder straps of her dress, letting it fall to the floor in a heap.

Catra and the crowd hollered louder. Adora's attention drifted around them. Several folks were apparently feeling amorous, the atmosphere of the room beginning to feel taut. Hands were starting to wander as bystanders got caught up in the energy. They nearly lost their minds with excitement when the performer's plum-colored lace corset and panties came into view.

Catra didn't seem to notice what everyone else was up to. Nor was she apparently as aware of how her and Adora's legs had

somehow gotten closer. Catra remained relaxed in her seat, even while she whistled and cupped her hand to shout towards the stage. Adora, on the other hand, felt herself squirming slightly in her spot. While the show was really appealing, her mind kept drifting to the harness Catra was wearing. And what her original plans had been for the night.

What was probably supposed to be a comforting hand landed on her shoulder. It was warm, in a room that felt like it couldn't possibly get any hotter. Maybe that water was a good idea after all.

Catra leaned closer to whisper, "Hey, if you're feeling weird, don't worry about it. No one's allowed to take photos or talk about what happens here so you're safe."

"Uh, thanks?" That hadn't actually been Adora's concern at all – she was out publicly and Freighton folks had always been protective of her – but it wasn't smart to disclose what was actually occupying her thoughts.

"If you want to leave, just let me know. There's a couple more performers before shit starts to get a little more... *real* around here." Catra went to take a sip of her drink, not removing her hand from Adora's shoulder.

Adora's head spun a little. She was out of her element. In a town she hadn't stepped foot in in years. In a booth with her former teammate and best friend (former everything). In a room so charged with tension that her own self-control might snap at any second. She felt a bit like getting carried away tonight.

It was all too wild to be happenstance. Most people didn't fly across the country and blow off work just to get face time with a reporter who covered them. Not without an intense complex or someone luring them there, at least.

That last thought made Adora pause and rapidly blink a few times. She trained her eyes back on Catra, who was now watching

a new person on stage explain the flogging demo she was about to give. People were literally lining up to volunteer.

“How much of this did you set up?” Adora asked. “This. Me. Here,” she added for clarity.

There was no accusation in her tone. Just curiosity. Catra always was very good at moving pieces around on the court however and wherever she needed them.

Catra laughed. “Honestly, I'd love to take credit but I genuinely had no idea you'd be here tonight.” She took a slow sip of her drink. “A little birdy told you where to find me?”

“Yep.”

“Same little birdy has taken a sudden interest in my whereabouts at all hours. Ever since the playoffs.”

Adora crinkled her face in thought. Razz *had* been talking about Catra more. What Catra was up to or what they’d most recently talked about. Adora was grateful but didn't think much of it. After all, she was the one who had finally started asking about Catra again. Once the-

“Your article was amazing by the way,” Adora said. She felt a little silly and a little breathless. She had asked about her childhood friend and now her aunt had accidentally set her up on a sex date.

“Which one?” Catra asked as she glanced over.

Adora huffed but didn’t give in. “All of them.”

“Yeah? What's your fave?”

In front of them, a burgundy-haired woman who could have been a supermodel was getting flogged and Adora couldn't be bothered to tear her eyes away from Catra. This was always her favorite part, going around in circles with Catra til they were both dizzy.

“Oh, well, that one about the Waste point guard,” Adora lied.

“And what about it resonated with you?”

“Why do I feel like you're trying to trick me?”

“Because you're naturally paranoid and avoidant of intimacy?” Catra said with a smirk.

“I think a doctor would call that projecting.”

Someone nearby shushed them. They weren’t exactly whispering anymore, surroundings completely forgotten.

Adora’s attention snapped towards a few people standing near them, still all focused on the stage. Catra rolled her eyes before moving closer to Adora's ear to whisper. So close that she was practically in Adora's lap. The hand that had been gently resting on the blonde’s shoulder moved to lean on the booth behind her.

“I barely write,” Catra said. There was just a hint of a sigh in her voice.

“You're such a great reporter though.”

“I'm a decent color commentator. No one really considers that journalism. I write pieces when I can but they barely get posted or picked up.”

“I still read all of them,” Adora admitted. Catra gave her the slightest look of shrewd disbelief. “I *do.* Razz usually sends them. That time you got printed, I think she bought a dozen copies of the paper and everything. She nearly lost her mind when I told her I'd just set up a Google alert for you so we’d never have to miss a story.”

“What a creep,” Catra whispered but she didn't move an inch.

Adora wanted to say something. Wanted to elaborate or explain herself or ask more questions but the whole thing felt like too

much to get into while there was a stranger in the room begging to be punished.

“This place has changed,” she observed instead.

Catra sounded almost bored when she replied. “This party lost its space. Scorpia wanted to give folks a safe place to play. Even after the show, it’s mostly just a hard R. Not even full triple X. It happens once a month. Had Razz tricked you into following me here literally any other day, you would’ve just found me playing pool.”

“But I would have missed the harness?” Adora joked in a low, suggestive voice.

Their eyes met again. Catra’s were different now, half-lidded, pupils slightly growing. Adora watched as she raked her gaze down to the blonde’s lips then past that to her body, lingering on her cleavage for just a moment. With a soft breath, Catra made eye contact once again.

“How you feelin’? You seem...tense.”

Yeah, that was one way to describe it. Another way would be to say that Adora was feeling completely okay with the idea of being laid out on this table right now with Catra underneath her.

But sure. Tense.

“Uh, yeah. A little.”

Catra nodded. “Want some help with that?”

Gods, yes.

“Okay,” Adora agreed, eager for whatever came next.

Catra stretched side to side and then leaned back, testing the give on the harness. It must have been unacceptable because she

undid the strap wrapping under her chest to loosen it one notch.

Adora gulped loudly.

“You sure you’re comfortable?” Catra asked again.

Adora nodded quickly since this was truly the only comfortable place she’d been all day. To prove this, she dribbled up to the three-point line and took an easy shoot. The sound of the net as the ball swooshed in on target was grounding. The fall chill in the air helped a bit too.

When Catra had driven straight to her house, Adora thought something else was on the menu for tonight. But Catra instructed her to wait in the bushes so that Razz wouldn’t peek out of her window next door and see her while Catra ran into the house. She returned with a basketball and led them down the block to the park.

The court was empty this time of night. Their only worry was Adora playing in a suit, which she promised that she’d had to do before. Charity auctions and public appearances usually, though. Not a full one-on-one game, which Catra seemed to be committed to.

“Looks like it’s your ball then,” Catra said, now apparently ready to go. She’d pulled her hair back into a huge ponytail that sat high on her head.

Adora paused to kick off her heels and leave them on the sidelines.

“Sure you don’t want to go first? Home court advantage and all,” Adora offered.

“Nah, I don’t need you taking pity on me. Your ball,” she said resolutely. “And don’t try to take it easy on me either. I’m in better shape than I look.”

“You look amazing,” Adora said without thinking. Catra turned and headed towards half-court as if she hadn’t heard that though.

Adora’s bare feet felt weird on the concrete but she figured it was only fair since Catra wasn’t wearing shoes either. She could barely walk in her heels so attempting to dunk in them was out of the question.

And she definitely *would* dunk – repeatedly too – just to show off and annoy Catra.

Focused and ready, Adora dribbled up to half-court and checked the ball to Catra. She checked it back to the blonde with a grin before crouching down defensively.

And then they were off. Adora did consider taking it easy on Catra but of course the latter wouldn’t lay off on her. Everywhere Adora went, Catra was right on top of her, playing aggressive d. She swiped at the ball. She kept her hands in Adora’s face. She stayed low and focused on the rock, not falling for any of Adora’s new fancy footwork.

She talked shit the whole time.

“I’ve seen mummies move more gracefully than this.”

“How’d you miss that shot? What were you – texting?”

“Your trash ball skills are why Mermista makes $5 million more than you.”

“Gods, Catra!” Adora finally laugh-yelled in frustration, still trying uselessly to back her up closer to the net for a spin move and easy lay-up. Catra hadn’t fallen for it once, cutting Adora off each time.

“Too far?” she asked. “Okay, I’ll stick to less personal things. Like how even a comatose person could see this pivot move you’re about to make.”

Even though it was telegraphed, Adora went for it, shifting the ball to her left hand and trying to pivot around Catra. She pulled up for a shot and Catra bit hard, fully leaping into the air to block. Instead, Adora ducked lower as Catra jumped by and turned it into an underhanded lay-up.

"That felt embarrassing," Adora said. "For me to watch, to be clear."

Catra grumbled, grabbed the ball, and went to line back up.

They continued back and forth like that, trading shots and barbs. It was probably the most fun Adora had had on a court in so long, outside of those kids charity games, which were always a blast.

This was different, obviously. The earlier tension between them hadn't dissipated but Adora was able to channel that into something concrete and possible, like winning this game, and ignore the theoretical and impossible thing she was aching for, like kissing Catra until she melted in Adora's arms.

It was hard work to resist that pull. The first place Adora ever realized she loved Catra was on a basketball court at 9 years old, when the tiny Magicat next door who never wanted to play with her suddenly came alive as soon as Adora tossed a ball to her. She was just all big hair and big eyes back then. Adora had tried to invite her over countless times but she barely spoke. When Catra's moms forced her to accompany Adora to the park, though, she transformed into this cocky trash-talking jerk who could run circles around the blonde.

Adora was instantly smitten.

They were a great combo together, but *against* each other? Catra always forced Adora to push herself harder, to freestyle, to try new things and trust her body to know what to do.

Now, Catra was still absurdly fast. With the ball in her hand, she kept Adora on her heels. She was barely winded, while Adora, who was sure she was in the best shape of her life, kept pausing

to take deep gulping breaths. Her suit was probably going to be ruined after this – could you dryclean sweat out of wool? Catra looked fucking effervescent.

Adora was *still* smitten.

Turns out playing barefoot and in formalwear was a great equalizer. She also allowed Catra to keep score, which was a mistake cause the numbers kept impossibly changing. So much so that when Catra took her spot just past half-court, checked the ball, and said “Game point,” Adora almost choked.

“Game point?!”

“Yeah, I've got 20, you've got 19,” Catra said, like Adora was being ridiculous.

“In what version of reality?!”

“The only one I'm recognizing here, champ. What? A washed up old burnout like me can't possibly beat you?”

“It was 17-13 just two minutes ago,” Adora pointed out.

“The scoreboard’s really changed you, man.”

With a roll of the eyes, Adora checked the ball back to her. “Still using the old rules?”

“Of course,” Catra scoffed. “Has society fallen apart?”

“So what does winner get this time?”

With her free hand, the one that wasn’t dribbling, Catra tapped a nail against her bottom lip. “Well, a pack of Now or Laters doesn't hold quite the same appeal it used to so... what do you want?”

“Can you come to next Thursday’s game?” It was the only time Adora would be home for three days in a row. Catra could stay and they'd make a whole weekend out of it. She'd be able to

show Catra the city. Take her out. Introduce her to Glimmer and Bow and all her other friends.

“Salineas? Nah, couldn't swing that so quickly.” Adora tried to hide her frown. Catra moved her hand to hip, drumming her claws as she thought. “Maybe a couple weeks from now when you're in Elberon.”

Adora was elated but. “How do you have the whole schedule memorized?”

Catra shrugged with one arm. “I've got dates, scores, and stats for three different college conferences in my head. Adding the Sharks is an easy lift.”

“So if I win, you'll come to the Elberon game?” Adora asked. She was trying not to light up in excitement but it was difficult. She could feel herself practically vibrating with joy. “I can fly you out and get you a hotel and everything.”

“Just get me the ticket, dummy. I can take care of the rest. I don't need you adding one more thing to your plate.”

Adora wanted to argue but this was already so much. She pursed her lips and nodded instead. “What do *you* get if you win?”

“The joy of conquering you,” Catra said simply.

She probably meant ‘at ball’ but that wasn't communicated to Adora's body, which basically shut down from horniness. With a laugh, Catra dribbled right around her.

“Driluth for the win!” she announced. Adora rebooted and turned herself around just in time to see Catra sink a short jumper from just a few inches west of the free-throw line.

The wide smile on her face as she spun around to Adora, arm still cocked in the air, was enough to make the blonde momentarily forget that she wouldn't be seeing Catra in two weeks.

“A stunning upset in Freighton tonight, folks!”

Not to be a sore loser, Adora gave Catra a generous round of applause – it was quite flat and unamused to be honest, but the fact that Adora applauded *at all* was generous in and of itself – as her opponent half-dropped into an over-the-top bow.

Right hand cocked into a fist as if she was holding an imaginary microphone, Catra slowly approached Adora.

“A couple questions, Grayskull?”

“I don’t think I have a choice here,” Adora replied. She used the opportunity to finally catch her breath and try to air the suit out a bit.

Catra affected a fake announcer voice that was thankfully nothing like what she actually used on air, over-enunciating her words and sounding like she was holding her breath or something. “You came into this game with a 0-300 record against your opponent, but experts believed you had the advantage for this one. This loss must hurt deeply.”

Catra leaned the fake mic closer to Adora. “That’s not a question. Also, *my opponent* is in charge of the recordkeeping and she’s a known liar and a dirty cheat.”

“I’m told that your opponent has a genius-level IQ and was placed in gifted classes all through school so she’s incapable of being wrong.”

The ‘microphone’ was thrust back into Adora’s face. “Again, not a question. My opponent took that test once on a website that I’m sure wasn’t qualified to make that assessment and then she flaunted the results for the rest of our lives.”

Catra withdrew her hand back to her own space. “Reflecting back on this heartbreaking loss, which of your opponent’s moves would you say was the most devastatingly impressive?”

Completely over this after years of similar showboating, Adora reached over and slipped her fingers over Catra's stomach until they were under the strap of the harness. Catra stopped in her tracks, probably half-way through asking another non-question to feed her superiority complex. Adora tugged until Catra was right in front of her. Her arms dropped to her sides and her mouth even went a little slack being so close to the blonde.

"Can you cut it out?" Adora asked with a laugh. "You won. Great job. I hope you really savor the joy of conquering me."

It was definitely supposed to be a joke but after everything tonight, Adora's words seemed to shift the air between them. She hadn't even really noticed what she was grabbing onto until it was too late.

Catra looked down at Adora's lips. Hand so close to her chest, Adora could feel as Catra's heartbeat sped up. When she looked back up, there was no trace of laughter on her face.

They'd only kissed once, right after they won the district championship their senior year of high school and Catra leapt into Adora's arms so quickly that their faces smacked together. More specifically, their lips had made direct contact and Adora was pretty sure she would've collapsed from shock if the entire school hadn't stormed the court to lift them both up in the air.

It's a thought that Adora often had but it at least made sense this time with Catra once again glancing down at her mouth. With Catra once again *moving towards* her mouth.

Adora felt herself instinctively leaning forward to meet her. Her free hand went to Catra's waist as two claws eased their way into her hair. This was how she'd often imagined them kissing in the past: on the court, illuminated only by streetlights, the sound of crickets chirping all around them.

But this wasn't a dream. And something just wasn't right.

"Wait...I just-can I say something?" Adora whispered.

Catra halted her progress immediately, only a breath away. She blinked quickly and looked up at Adora's eyes. Catra's face was a mix of confusion and worry but Adora had to get this out before they went any further.

Adora cleared her throat. She'd practiced this a few times in the past months. What came out, unfortunately, was a mash-up of half-thoughts. "I'm sorry I didn't win. We came so close and you wrote that piece. I know you were reminding me of our promise when I left."

'Don't bother coming back unless you're coming back with a title.'

Catra's lips dropped into a deep frown, but Adora continued.

"I thought if I followed through than it would make leaving you behind worth it and-"

"Good Gods, we're both such fucking pieces of work," Catra muttered, aghast.

"What??"

"Dude. I was 19 and pissed and in love with you. And I had all of 2 whole brain cells. I didn't know what else to say besides that stupid joke. I used to think about that all the time – if I'd had the sense to say something real, would we have at least kept in touch more regularly?"

"You were in love with me?" Adora heard herself ask. It sounded far away though, probably because her experience of reality was greatly shifting.

"And the article – I genuinely just think you're amazing and wanted more people to know that. Everyone's all wrapped up in magazine covers and models you're dating but your numbers – 'Dor, you're playing like a woman possessed. And so smart too. I know Hope isn't doing shit but wearing a cheap suit and yelling at the refs. You're actually leading the offense."

“Yeah, well, cause I'm pulling a few of your tricks,” Adora managed to joke.

“I expect a 30% cut of all earnings for that by the way. Or I’ll have to see you in court.”

“You're in love with me?” Adora tried again.

But Catra was now on a roll so stopping her was out of the question. “And leaving me behind? I'm a big girl, Adora. I don't need you to save me. I never expected you to take me anywhere. I loved playing college ball here, even though, yeah, it sucked when you joined the draft after freshman year. And I love my job. I get to yell about stats and make fun of an old white person on TV twice a week. It's basically my dream. I love writing my self-indulgent pieces, even if no one bothers reading them.”

“Now I think you're just naming things you love to make it sound like you didn't say what you definitely said,” Adora muttered.

“And you waited to come home until you got a fucking *trophy?!* What am I? World's worst stepdad?” Suddenly, Catra narrowed her eyes and gripped Adora’s hair harder to pull her closer. “Don't you ever fucking stay away this long again.”

“You-”

“Yes, I was in love with you, you idiot,” Catra added with a put-upon sigh that had Adora rolling her eyes. “Everyone gave me shit for *weeks* for that article. Like I was writing a love letter to my wife who's away at war.”

“ *Was?* Past tense?”

“Well. I haven't been just sitting around for 7 years and waiting on you. I've dated. Thought I was in love a couple of those times. But yeah, something’s still there. Always will be probably. You're tenacious like that.” This close, Adora could see the small smile Catra tried to hide.

“Yeah? Me too. All of that,” Adora said too quickly.

Catra looked very unimpressed. “What an amazing and articulate declaration.”

“Well, not all of us finished college. Or majored in journalism.”

“I got to appear in a local used car ad and everything,” Catra pretended to boast.

“Oh, shit. The big time.” Adora smiled. “So.”

“So... we doing this?”

She probably expected Adora to lob something back. Instead, the blonde kissed Catra. A *real* kiss, like she always wanted. Catra’s lips were soft but insistent, parting and wordlessly asking for Adora’s tongue quickly. She tasted a bit like whiskey and those herby sage bitters, which Adora made a mental note to actually try next time she was in town.

The kiss made Adora feel light-headed, as if she was floating on air. The whole night had somehow gotten away from her; this was just the final piece of an unforgettable, unreal evening.

And then Catra bit down hard on Adora’s bottom lip while trying to push her hips closer and the blonde realized that this didn’t necessarily *have* to be the end of the night. It wasn’t like she had a flight home to catch or anything. The thoughts of how they could fill their time made her groan against her will, Catra growling at the sound.

Catra’s hands drifted down from Adora’s hair down her back to grip at her ass, leaving goosebumps in her wake. Their kisses grew frantic, hot against the chill in the air.

“Can I touch you?” Catra asked. She refused to move back so she basically mumbled the words right into Adora’s mouth.

“Uh huh,” Adora mumbled back.

The request had her heart racing. Between Catra's just general *presence* , the scotch, and the show earlier, she'd been turned on all night. But being this close had Adora aching in a way that she never had before.

One of Catra's hands was soon on the move again and Adora was practically breathless with anticipation. It slipped under her jacket to lightly scratch along her side and tummy.

"Fuck," Adora whispered between kisses.

"Already? You're not even gonna be able to *handle* what comes next then."

Catra popped open the button of Adora's pants and pulled the zipper down just enough to slip her hand inside. Her fingertips were warm as they trailed over the outside of Adora's underwear. She was grateful that she'd worn the fancy ones today, just in case.

When Catra finally cupped Adora between her legs, the shock just about buckled her knees. Catra had to lean in closer to hold Adora up, chuckling out, "Called it," to herself.

She wasn't doing much. Just resting her hand there while Adora got used to it probably. Her palm was warm and Adora's hips rushed forward to get more contact. It felt so good – maddeningly so – and made Adora greedy for more.

She gave a sharp tug on the harness in the hopes that it would convince Catra to continue exploring.

Adora was sorta so distracted by trying to get what she wanted without actually just asking for it, that she didn't notice the approaching car.

Not until she heard the loud, piercing siren.

Adora nearly jumped out of her skin, heart thundering in her chest. Catra had the presence of mind to retrieve her hand

quickly. Adora opened her eyes to see a white police cruiser, red and blue lights flashing, making their way into the parking lot of the park and towards them.

As was the protocol when they were kids, Catra took off without another word. She'd sprinted right off the court before Adora could even wrap her head around what was happening. Figuring she'd probably be ruined if she was arrested for getting fingered in a public park though, Adora swiftly followed.

She had to button her pants and pick up the ball, but she almost caught up to Catra as they hopped the metal fence, cackling uncontrollably the whole way.

Just in case they were followed, they had to cut through a neighbor's yard and enter Catra's house through the backdoor. That also helped ensure that the likelihood of Razz catching them and interrogating them was pretty low.

The adrenaline from the near-miss with the cops hadn't worn off yet. At least, that was how Adora rationalized it as she boldly pushed Catra against the kitchen door and asked, "Do you want me to fuck you? Cause I would *really really* like that."

"You're fucking hot when you're saying what you want," Catra told her, voice intense. "Yeah, Dor, I really want that."

Catra's pants were a little harder to get into than Adora's. Who knew why she insisted on wearing them so fucking tight? Adora was close to just ripping them and apologizing later when Catra lowered them just a couple inches or so, enough that Adora's fingers finally reached their destination.

Catra threw her head back into the door with a moan as Adora touched her clit. She was slick and hot enough that Adora's hand practically glided against her.

Adora took a half-step back to watch. She wanted to see all of Catra's reactions, find out what felt good for her. With heavily

lidded eyes, Catra watched her right back, lips parted, body tense. She kept her hips thrusting forward into Adora's touch, clearly chasing more pressure. Adora obliged slightly by sliding a second finger onto Catra's clit but kept her focus on steadying her movements, driving Catra wilder.

There was a certain sense of pride that she got from feeling how completely soaked Catra was. Obviously, Adora was too. It was just nice to know that they were *mutually* a complete mess for each other. For so long, Adora had thought her feelings for Catra, her *need* for Catra, was some secret she had to hold alone in her heart. Now, it felt safe to pour all of that love into Catra. And also maybe to fuck Catra so well that she'd be inspired to fly to Salineas for more.

With a sharp gasp, Catra quivered against the door, reaching to pull Adora closer. Her claws fumbled as they unbuttoned the blonde's blazer. Cool air hit Adora's midsection, revealing her gold lace bralette.

"Gods, you're gorgeous," Catra breathed out as her eyes lingered on Adora's tits. "Come on,"she said, pushing away from the door.

She seemed reluctant to part them so Adora had to walk backward out of the kitchen and down the hall, using only her memory of the place and Catra's guiding hands for direction. They stumbled into the bedroom with her hand still furiously working Catra's clit, though her motions had gotten a little sloppy along the way. A coat or something soft-sounding fell to the floor quietly. Adora turned to make sure she wasn't being a complete wreck, only to have her face caught and held in place by Catra's hands.

"Ignore them," Catra instructed.

"Who?"

"Mrroww," the not-coat complained.

It moved a bit and Adora could see, even with the lights still off, a set of shining blue eyes that were almost a pale turquoise.

“Did you get a kitty?!” Adora practically cooed.

“Adora,” Catra whined. “I’ll give you a tour later so you can ‘ooh’ and ‘ah’ at everything, including Melog. *After* you make me cum all over you.”

“... *all* ov-?”

Her words were cut off by Catra’s lips back on hers and soon Adora felt her weight being dragged down as they collapsed onto the bed. Catra was quick to begin ripping all of their clothes off. Adora had to reluctantly finally stop touching her to help, torn between wanting to continue uninterrupted and wanting to see Catra naked for the first time in a non-locker room setting.

Catra paused at the harness. “On?” she offered.

“Next time?” was Adora's unsure reply. It was a tempting offer, a built-in way to possibly get Catra to behave. But for now, she kinda just wanted the woman underneath her with no distractions.

“There’s a next time?” Catra asked, sounding vulnerable. “Promise?”

Adora locked eyes with her. “I promise,” she swore.

Catra wasted no time in finishing her task as she returned to removing Adora's underwear.

She was almost giddy when she randomly said, “I’m so glad we didn’t fuck when we were younger. I’ve gotten a lot better at it.”

Adora couldn't help but laugh. “Me too.”

She was pulled down again as Catra tugged Adora's body fully on top of her own. Wrapping her legs around the blonde's waist, her arms locked behind Adora's neck to fully keep her in place.

That smokey vanilla scent that Adora had caught hints of earlier was all around them. There was something soothing about it, something that helped ease Adora's worries. She'd dreamt of this moment for so long that she was acutely aware of doing anything that could possibly fuck it up. The nerves in her stomach were only barely being outpaced by how much she desperately wanted this.

"You okay?" Catra asked, somehow pulling her even tighter into her embrace.

Adora nodded quickly. She was. She was excellent in high-pressure situations, that was her whole thing!

And so Adora definitely did not repeat her mantra from the bar in her head until she relaxed into Catra's arms. "*You* okay?"

"10 out of 10," Catra responded, sounding suspiciously nervous.

At least they were in this together. Adora moved to kiss right under her fluffy ears until the tension in Catra's body felt like the good kind.

"Fuck," she groaned. "Can you be inside me now?"

With a grateful 'yes', Adora attempted to shift her weight so that she had the optimum angle. But Catra clung on like she was being rescued from a burning building.

"Catra," Adora laughed. "We're basically smooshed together."

"Make it work then."

Adora huffed but complied. She slipped one arm under Catra's neck to hold her in place – redundant since she clearly wasn't going anywhere. The other arm just barely fit between their bodies. Adora teased at Catra's nipples, feeling them get hard as she gripped them gently between her fingers. Her nails scratched through the soft tawny fur on Catra's tummy until she felt claws impatiently digging into her own shoulders.

They both stilled as soon as her fingers slid into Catra. Adora watched her eyes go wide but was too busy having her mind blown to say anything comprehensible.

"Holy fuck," Catra gasped. "Deeper."

Adora followed obediently, pushing up to the knuckle until her palm was firm against Catra's clit.

Catra buried her face into the blonde's neck, mumbling what sounded like 'love you'. Heart racing, Adora dug her knees into the mattress for traction and began eagerly thrusting, filling Catra over and over.

For some reason, she expected Catra to be quiet. Catra could be private and reserved when she wanted, though she had a tendency to loudly proclaim her own superiority.

Catra was *not* quiet. Not at all. She swore, which wasn't really a surprise, nor was the amount of direction she gave on when Adora should switch speeds or angles. But she also pleaded for more. She repeated how much she wanted Adora, how much she needed Adora. (A few times, it seemed like she professed her love again but it was hard to parse that out from the multiple variations of 'I love how you're fucking me' so Adora just stopped trying.)

Adora was on cloud nine. To be the person who brought Catra so much pleasure was intoxicating. She silently thanked the gods that the game before had helped ensure that she wasn't *actually* intoxicated cause she wouldn't want to risk not remembering a single moment of this. How wet Catra was for her. How her voice changed from its usual low register to something resembling her squeaky laugh when she got closer to cumming. How she held Adora tighter and tighter until it felt like her arms could possibly hold anymore tension.

And then the dam started to break. Catra screamed, "Don't stop," as if that were ever an option for Adora.

“I won’t,” she swore. “I’ve got you. I’ll take care of you. Are you gonna cum for me?” She paused, remembering Catra’s words. With a smirk, Adora added, “Are you gonna cum all over me?”

Adora hissed as claws instantly dug into her traps. Her teammates were gonna have some questions about that in a couple days.

She felt Catra’s pussy tighten deliciously before it grew impossibly wetter. Catra released another unintelligible high-pitch scream that ended in a low growl before her limbs eased their snake-like grip on Adora’s body.

Adora slowed the movement of her fingers to a stand still but kept the pressure of her palm on Catra’s clit as she twitched with aftershocks.

It felt like she should say... *something.* Adora’s heart was so full that it seemed like the moment called for some kind of commemoration. She never was very good at speeches though, and Catra, looking half-asleep on her pillow, wouldn’t make a very good audience.

She opened her mouth to freestyle something short anyway when Catra’s eyes suddenly shot open.

“What are you doing?” she asked suspiciously.

“Uh...I was gonna check on you?” Adora replied.

“Literally never been better,” Catra told her but her voice was gravelly, probably from all of the shouting, and she looked about three seconds away from hibernating for a week. “Your turn.”

Catra flipped them so quickly that Adora’s head literally spun. In a blink, she was on her back with Catra moving to situate herself at Adora’s side. She shivered as a furry leg draped between her own, Catra using it to spread her thighs and keep them open. Catra wrapped an arm under Adora’s neck, like the blonde had done for her.

“That was fucking amazing,” Catra whispered into her ear before sucking the lobe into her warm mouth. Adora blushed both from the praise and from the hand that began drifting across her chest. “Now, lay back and relax.”

It was near-impossible to stay relaxed as Catra’s mouth followed the route set by her fingers, biting and sucking at Adora’s nipples until she left a constellation of forming hickies. She kept her claws out as she teased at Adora’s hips and thighs. Yes, it had occurred to her that pain was a likely side effect of finally fucking Catra. It just hadn’t occurred to Adora that she would like it so much.

Even Catra seemed surprised by that, scratching harder, testing her limits, until Adora begged, “Please touch me.”

“Oh, is that what you want?” Catra asked in a detached tone that didn’t at all match how she added more pressure as she trailed her nails up the inside of Adora’s thigh.

“Cat,” Adora groaned. This was *not* the time to be trying to teach her a valuable lesson about stating her needs.

“I wanna hear you say it,” Catra whispered. “I need to hear you say that you want me and you want me to fuck you.”

Just a hint of doubt colored Catra’s words. There was no way that Adora could let that stand. Catra absolutely had to know how very much she was desired right now.

“Cat, I want you,” Adora just about panted. “I’ve always wanted you. I want you to fuck me. Right now. *Please.”*

She arched her back as Catra entered her, already trying to get more.

“Relax,” Catra repeated. Adora had to bite the inside of her cheek to comply.

Catra returned her lips to Adora’s chest, biting along her collarbone and throat as she began to pump in and out.

She moved at a much slower and steadier pace than the frantic one that Adora had kept with her. It left Adora teetering on the edge for a good while, particularly once Catra swiveled her hand so that her thumb could rub at Adora's throbbing clit.

Adora felt the sheets ball in her hands as she grabbed at them for something to hold onto. Her knees attempted to close as her body braced for release but Catra's thigh kept them wedged apart while she worked.

Again, breaking expectations, Catra didn't make her beg for it. Just when Adora thought she couldn't take anymore, Catra picked up speed. Adora could hear the slick sound of Catra fucking her so deeply. She could feel Catra (probably unconsciously) grinding her own pussy against Adora's hips in time with each thrust, moaning into Adora's ear as she sucked at her neck.

Adora tightened her hold on the sheets until her hands started to ache a little. She took one last breath, held it, and then let first the wave of pleasure take her.

When Adora finally opened her eyes again, Catra was still half-laid across her. Except now, she was using her forehead to rub her scent all over Adora's neck and cheeks. It was only when Catra realized that Adora had finally moved again, tossing her a little smirk, that Adora saw the fake microphone Catra was once again making with her fist.

"Not this again," Adora tried to say but her throat was way too dry.

"How successful would you say you were at getting penetration tonight?" Catra asked, using that awful announcer voice.

All Adora could do in response was heave dry, coughing laughs.

"You really went hard at the hole. What was your thinking there?"

Adora tried waving Catra away but her arms wouldn't comply and lift more than an inch off the bed.

"Were you able to stick to your game plan?"

Adora finally gave up and tilted her head towards Catra's hand. "Definitely not." With a devilish smile, she said, "I saw what the other side was giving though, pivoted, and ended up coming out on top."

"Well, there will be a rematch in two weeks. Now that the other team knows your strategy, things will probably go differently."

"I'm a versatile player," Adora answered automatically. It took a few seconds before her brain, previously reduced to mush, was able to catch up. "Wait....two weeks? But you won."

Catra dropped her hand, lying it gently on Adora's stomach. "Just because you've lost a step doesn't mean we both have to suffer."

Adora used all of her remaining energy to pull Catra down into a kiss. Gratitude, elation, renewed love – all bubbled in Adora's chest until she was sure a couple of tears were escaping her eyes.

Catra was coming to her game. Truly, it was the best possible outcome from Adora's surprise appearance. They'd definitely have to keep talking, keep getting to re-know each other and figure things out. But this was a first step. And Catra was making it.

Adora was so happy, she was sure that she wouldn't be able to sit still. She already wanted to rush off and make all the preparations. Draw up plans for all the ways they'd spend time together and the new memories they could make.

She glanced back at Catra, who was lying there watching Adora with such fond exasperation in her eyes. Adora realized she could probably wait just a little longer to hammer out the details. She had nowhere to be except this bed for tonight.

With a happy sigh, she allowed herself to relax. “I have an assistant-type person. She’ll set up the ticket and the flight and everything tomorrow morning.”

“Cool,” Catra said casually.

“Cool,” Adora repeated.

“Now, flip over. You’re little spoon,” Catra told her, making a circle motion with her index finger.

“I thought I was getting a tour.”

“You should’ve known that was a trick to get you to speed up.”

Adora grumbled but Catra just kept making that same circle motion, growing more impatient by the second.

Finally, Adora flipped over onto her other side. She had only just noticed that it was starting to get chilly in the room. And her body was exhausted now that it had had a second to calm down. Maybe just a few hours of sleep wasn’t a bad idea.

Catra pulled a soft sheet and a heavy fluffy blanket over the two of them as she molded herself to Adora’s back. Her fur felt heavenly against the human’s skin, like Adora was encased in a cloud of comfort.

“And, ‘Dor? Tell her we won’t be needing a separate hotel room.”

Nope, she sighed to herself as she melted into Catra’s arms, *we definitely won’t*.

End Notes

here's some random basketball thoughts:
this is at least partially inspired by all the basketball dates on the bachelorette this season.
the wiki for 21 is not how i grew up playing it (free throws? bro, you had to physically fight for every point)
etheria's basketball season runs like the nba and not the wnba for writer's personal needs.
i played basketball for like three years on the girls team, which is so funny to me now. i quit to manage the team, a job that i feel like i was really born to do: getting water bottles ready, making sure the uniforms were clean, holding the gym door open while the cheerleading coach chainsmoked marlboro reds outside.

anyway. thanks, enig17ma! hope you enjoyed this.

i'm on twitter at @pettiestlabelle if that's your jam.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!